CSIS | KOREA DAILY BRIEF

Sunday, November 8, 2026 No. 228 12 min read

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. North Korea fired two ballistic missiles from Muncheon toward the East Sea, traveling approximately 350 km.
2. Senior US Navy and Marine Corps officials visited HD Hyundai's Ulsan shipyard on Nov. 4 to assess naval shipbuilding under MASGA.
3. FM Cho Hyun departed for Paris to meet Secretary of State Rubio at the G7 foreign ministers meeting, their first face-to-face since the midterms.

KOSPI	USD/KRW	BRENT	LEE APPROVAL	KIM LAST SEEN	BOK RATE
5,059.69	1,356.34	$98.32	39%	Today	3.00%
−6.0%	+1.2%	+0.0%	flat Oct 27-29	public appearance	Oct 2026

01 TOP STORIES

JTBC, DPRK

North Korea fires two ballistic missiles from Muncheon toward East Sea

North Korea launched *two ballistic missiles* from the Muncheon area toward the East Sea, with a reported flight distance of approximately 350 km, JTBC reported Sunday.

The launch marks the fifth weapons test in roughly a week, following an air-defense surface-to-air missile test and a cruise missile airport-strike drill confirmed by state media on Nov. 6. The US State Department separately called for international coordination against North Korean cyber threats following FBI attribution of the Binance hack to Pyongyang.

Yonhap, US-Korea

Senior US Navy and Marine Corps officials assess HD Hyundai's Ulsan shipyard under MASGA

A US delegation including Assistant Secretary of the Navy **Brendan P. Rogers**, Marine Corps Lt. Gen. **Andrew M. Niebel**, and Maj. Gen. **Valerie A. Jackson** visited HD Hyundai Heavy Industries' Ulsan shipyard on Nov. 4 to evaluate naval shipbuilding capabilities, installation infrastructure, and logistics support. The visit was posted on the Pentagon's Defense Visual Information Distribution Service and cited opportunities to strengthen maritime sustainment and operational readiness. HD Hyundai signed a joint venture agreement with US construction firm Kiewit in October to build a new US shipyard, with operations targeted for 2029.

Yonhap TV, US-Korea

FM Cho Hyun flies to Paris for G7 foreign ministers meeting, first face-to-face with Rubio since midterms

Cho Hyun departed for Paris to attend the G7 foreign ministers meeting, where he is expected to hold his first in-person talks with US Secretary of State **Marco Rubio** since the Democratic Party's midterm victory.

Korean media flagged the meeting as an opportunity to advance discussions on the nuclear submarine cooperation file and broader security consultations stalled by US domestic politics. Multiple outlets also noted that South Korea's Army and Navy chiefs of staff are scheduled to visit Japan this month for talks with Japan Self-Defense Forces leadership.

GNA, ROK Politics

National Assembly passes 'fabricated prosecution' special counsel bill

The ROK National Assembly plenary passed the Special Counsel Act to investigate alleged fabrication of criminal prosecutions under the Yoon Suk Yeol administration, covering 12 cases including the Daejang-dong, Wirye, and Baekseok-dong development scandals in which President **Lee Jae-myung** had been indicted.

The Justice Ministry's own investigative panel found no evidence of fabricated prosecution in a first-round review of three cases, a finding that legal scholars say burdens the special counsel before it launches. Critics in the opposition People Power Party contend a structural conflict of interest exists because the president, himself a defendant in the cases, will appoint the special counsel.

02 | OVERNIGHT

Yonhap, DPRK

North Korea holds 10th Congress of Union of Agricultural Workers, pledges grain and livestock innovation

Beyond grain; calls livestock, orchards, vegetable production overhaul.

NK News, DPRK

North Korea expands warship construction to a third shipyard

Third facility confirmed; adds to Nampho and Sinpo capacity.

Daily NK, DPRK

Firewood and coal prices double in Ryanggang province after cold snap; low-income families cannot prepare for winter

Temperatures below freezing since late October in highland areas.

Daily NK, DPRK

North Koreans avoid saying 'unification' as Kim's two-hostile-states doctrine enters constitution

Fear of slip drives self-censorship; word taboo spreading to daily speech.

SBS, Technology

Nvidia CEO's daughter cancels Seoul trip amid intelligence reports of spy link to Jensen Huang

Cancellation one day before 'Nvidia AI Day Seoul 2026'; event proceeds without her.

Hankyoreh, Technology

US midterm data-center regulation wave: Goldman sees 45% of US projects at risk of review or halt

Incoming Democratic governors in Texas, New York, Arizona pledged freezes.

Hankyoreh, ROK Economy

Seoul National University selects mechanical engineering professor Choi Hae-cheon as next president

First engineering-background SNU president in 20 years; term begins Feb. 2027.

03 | STAT OF THE DAY

-6.02%

KOSPI single-session decline, Nov. 6

The KOSPI fell 6.02% on Nov. 6, the sharpest session drop tied to the US midterm results and AI sector selloff hitting Samsung and SK Hynix.

Nikkei Korea, 'Taiwan, South Korea, Japan stock markets hit hard by AI sell-off'

04 | PYONGYANG WATCH

Kim Jong Un

Public appearance: Kim Jong Un inspected a new warship under construction at Nampho Shipyard on Nov. 7 and ordered strengthening of surface and underwater naval capabilities alongside modernization of the facility.

No KCNA watch flag. 7 provocations logged in the last 7 days.

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

Yonhap News Agency

WPK delegation head Kim Sung-nam holds third high-level meeting in China, tours CPC Central Party School

North Korea's Workers' Party International Secretary Kim Sung-nam completed a five-day China visit with his third high-level meeting, including a session with a member of the Secretariat of the Central Committee of the Chinese Communist Party.

SENIOR OFFICIALS

Kim Sung-nam, WPK International Secretary

Kim Sung-nam concluded a five-day visit to China, meeting senior Chinese Communist Party officials including a member of the CPC Secretariat and touring the CPC Central Party School before returning to Pyongyang.

> **Bottom line:** State media confirmed Kim Jong Un's Nampho Shipyard inspection and naval modernization orders, while KCNA also carried the 10th Congress of the Union of Agricultural Workers, all four recent weapons tests remain off the domestic news agenda.

05 | ROK GOVERNMENT

President and ministries, Sunday, November 8, 2026

MINISTRY OF UNIFICATION

Unification Ministry spokesperson

Unification Ministry says sanctions on North Korea over Binance hack not yet under discussion

A Unification Ministry official stated that Seoul has not yet begun discussing additional sanctions over the Binance cryptocurrency theft attributed by the FBI to North Korea, because the full circumstances have not been established. MOFA separately said it was 'reviewing' options, creating a visible split in the ROK government's public posture on the sanctions question.

Korea Times

OFFICE OF THE PRIME MINISTER

Prime Minister Han Seong-sook

Government-ruling party consultation agrees to review 2 trillion won in firefighting finance support

Prime Minister Han Seong-sook chaired the 12th senior government-ruling party consultation session, agreeing to review approximately 2 trillion won in central government funding to relieve provincial firefighting budget burdens. Additional budget for firefighting equipment, training facilities, and specialized medical infrastructure will be incorporated into next year's budget review; the meeting was held the day before the 64th anniversary of the Day of Firefighting.

Yonhap

MINISTRY OF TRADE, INDUSTRY AND ENERGY

MOTIE Minister

MOTIE minister completes 3-day China trip including Korea-China commerce ministers meeting and Shanghai Expo visit

The Minister of Trade, Industry and Energy completed a two-night, three-day trip to China, holding a Korea-China commerce ministers meeting and meeting Korean and Chinese business leaders in Shanghai and Shandong Province. The minister posted that he was 'more alarmed' by the pace of Chinese industrial development after visiting the Shanghai International Import Expo, where Samsung, SK, and over 150 small- and medium-sized Korean companies were exhibiting.

Minister, Trade/Industry (MOTIR) on X

PERSONNEL CHANGES

Lee Yong-cheol NOMINATED

Minister of Justice (nominee)

President Lee Jae-myung nominated Lee Yong-cheol as justice minister. The People Power Party alleges Lee Yong-cheol was a hidden architect of the Daejang-dong project and argues the appointment is designed to facilitate withdrawal of charges against the president. His confirmation hearing is set for November 12.

06 | US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

TARIFF STATUS

Autos and parts Section 232	**15%** Reduced
Steel and aluminum Section 232	**50%** Active
Reciprocal tariff 10% surcharge (Section 122), expired Jul 24 2026	**Expired**
Section 301 USTR, Section 301 determination, pending, no fixed date	**Active**

6 more sector rates on the trade reference page; no rate changed since the last issue.

Steel and aluminum remain at 50% and automobiles at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 reciprocal surcharge expired July 24, leaving no single baseline tariff on Korean goods. Section 301 investigations launched March 11 are now the primary prospective vehicle for new tariff action.

INVESTMENT PLEDGE, $350B

$350B pledged; 1 project selected so far, led by Encinal gas-fired power plant, Texas ($22.3B).

$150B shipbuilding (MASGA), $200B strategic sectors, $100B energy purchases; no official Strategic Investment Corporation drawdown figure reported to date.

07 | CAPITOL HILL

Todayville, Legislation

US lawmakers race to make Chinese car ban permanent before congressional session ends

US legislators are pushing to codify the ban on Chinese-manufactured vehicles before the current congressional session expires, a measure with direct implications for South Korean automakers competing in the US market who would benefit from continued exclusion of Chinese rivals.

08 NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

USNI News, China-Korea

Kim Jong Un inspects new warship at Nampho Shipyard, orders naval capability strengthening

Kim Jong Un inspected a new warship under construction at Nampho Shipyard on Nov. 7 and ordered strengthening of surface and underwater capabilities alongside modernization of the facility, per USNI News. Reporting from 재경일보 cites speculation the vessel may be a 10,000-ton class cruiser, with Kim ordering acceleration of naval modernization beyond the destroyer launched last year.

upi, China-Korea

Wang Yi meets North Korean WPK envoy in Beijing, pledges closer ties

Chinese Foreign Minister **Wang Yi** met with the North Korean Workers' Party delegation headed by International Secretary Kim Sung-nam in Beijing, with China pledging to strengthen bilateral ties. This was Kim Sung-nam's third high-level meeting during a five-day visit to China that also included a tour of the Chinese Communist Party Central Party School.

SBS, Japan-Korea

South Korea's Army and Navy chiefs of staff to visit Japan this month for JSDF talks

South Korea's Army chief of staff and Navy chief of staff are both scheduled to visit Japan in mid-November for bilateral talks with their Japan Self-Defense Forces counterparts, SBS reported. The visits follow a period of intensified trilateral coordination under the Camp David framework and come as Seoul is managing North Korea's accelerated weapons testing tempo.

SBS, Japan-Korea

Japan PM Takaichi vows to resolve abductee issue through Kim Jong Un summit in her term

Japanese Prime Minister **Takaichi Sanae** stated she is committed to resolving the Japanese abductee issue through a summit with North Korean leader **Kim Jong Un** within her term. The statement reflects Tokyo's sustained diplomatic push on the abductee file, which has periodically intersected with broader US-DPRK diplomatic openings.

09 KOREA AND THE WORLD

Defence24, Europe, Defense exports

South Korea and Turkey deepen defense cooperation as two defense industrial powers join forces

South Korea and Turkey are expanding defense industrial cooperation, with Defence24 describing the two countries as complementary defense powers. The partnership reflects South Korea's continued effort to diversify its defense export base beyond traditional markets in Southeast Asia and the Middle East.

Trend News Agency, Central Asia, Trade

Kazakhstan raises crude oil exports to South Korea by 12% in January-August 2026

Kazakhstan increased crude oil exports to South Korea by *12%* in the January-August 2026 period compared to the prior year, reflecting Seoul's ongoing effort to diversify energy supply sources away from Middle Eastern suppliers amid elevated oil prices.

Asia Economy, Southeast Asia, Aid

South Korea to share disaster safety technology with ASEAN through officials' training program

South Korea will conduct a training program for ASEAN government officials focused on disaster safety technology, expanding its development assistance footprint across Southeast Asia. The program is part of Seoul's broader ASEAN engagement strategy.

10 BUSINESS & ECONOMY

Nikkei

KOSPI falls 6% as AI selloff hammers Taiwan, South Korea, Japan tech stocks

South Korea's KOSPI dropped *6.02%* on Nov. 6 alongside Taiwan and Japanese equity markets, driven by the US midterm Democratic wave triggering concern over data center construction restrictions affecting demand for high-bandwidth memory. Samsung Electronics and SK Hynix, as primary suppliers of AI-related memory, bore the brunt of the decline.

Samsung Electronics SK Hynix

thekorea.kr, Primary

FSS suspends brokerage margin collateral requirements as emergency volatility measure

South Korea's securities regulator suspended margin collateral ratio requirements for securities firms' credit lending as an emergency measure to address market volatility following the KOSPI's sharp decline. The measure is intended to prevent forced margin calls from amplifying the selloff.

The Times of India

Samsung set to become first South Korean company with 200 trillion won in cash

Samsung is on track to become the first South Korean company to hold *200 trillion won* in cash reserves, according to reporting by The Times of India citing Korean financial data. The figure underscores Samsung's liquidity position even as its stock has been hit by the AI-driven selloff.

Samsung Electronics

Seoul Economic Daily

South Korean government to release digital assets regulatory framework bill this month

The ROK government plans to release its draft Digital Assets Act this month, establishing a regulatory framework for virtual asset businesses and investor protection measures. The legislation comes as South Korea's FSC has been reviewing exchange security after the Binance hack attributed to North Korea.

11 UPCOMING

NOV 12

Justice minister nominee Lee Yong-cheol confirmation hearing

Lee Yong-cheol, nominated as justice minister, will attend his National Assembly confirmation hearing on November 12 amid opposition allegations of Daejang-dong links.

NOV 16

Hoover Institution event: Reading Adam Smith in North Korea

The Hoover Institution Northeast Asia History Working Group hosts journalist and North Korean defector Joo Sung Ha for a public discussion of North Korean society, education, and culture at the George P. Shultz Building, Stanford.

12 ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

Lee Jae-myung (@Jaemyung_Lee), November 7

“We will block privatization of the public sector that increases the burden on the people. Separating KTX and SRT was part of a plan to privatize the best-performing portions of rail by selling them to the private sector. By integrating the two, we have reduced the possibility of privatization while improving efficiency through fare reductions and increased ridership.”

The government's integration of the two rail services is presented as a policy line against privatization ahead of the 2028 general election cycle. **View on X**

Han Seong-sook (@han_seongsook), November 8

"We will not leave even a small gap in public safety during the winter season. Today we held a senior government-ruling party consultation to discuss expansion of fire service finance and the winter natural disaster response plan. The government regards the safety and lives of the people as the most important value."

The consultation agreed to review approximately 2 trillion won in central firefighting finance support, to be incorporated into next year's budget review. **View on X**

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.

STATEMENTS

Lee Jae-myung

"Praise but do not worship, support but do not revere. Democracy does not come on its own and is not preserved on its own. Only the endless participation and practice of citizens who respond to truth and justice with living reason creates and preserves democracy."

Source

Gen. Xavier Brunson

"Readiness depends on access, sustainment, and committed partners. In Tokyo, I met with Minister Koizumi and thanked him for Japan's continued support to UN Command-Rear."

The visit to Tokyo follows the confirmation that South Korea's Army and Navy chiefs of staff are also scheduled to visit Japan in mid-November for JSDF leadership talks. **Source**

COMMENTARY

Talks, Attacks, and a Heist. The piece surveys adversary strategy in the post-midterm landscape, with a section addressing the North Korean Binance hack as a revenue-generation and diplomatic spoiler. It places the heist in the context of Pyongyang's pattern of using cyber operations to fund weapons programs while simultaneously probing for diplomatic openings. (War on the Rocks editorial staff, War on the Rocks)

Editorial: Special Counsel Bill Forced Through, Is 'We Lost Because of the President' Someone Else's Story?. It also notes that the Justice Ministry's own internal review found no evidence of fabricated prosecution, weakening the bill's premise before the investigation begins. (Chosun Ilbo editorial board, Chosun Ilbo)

13 | PUBLIC SENTIMENT

Lee approval

39%

0 pts vs Oct 13-15
Gallup Korea
October 27-29, 2026

Trend: Down from 42% on Aug 25-27, across 7 readings.

Ruling	Opposition	Independents
Democratic	People Power	
35%	30%	28%

Gallup Korea publishes weekly; this reading is 1 week old (October 27-29, 2026).

14 | THE WIRE

DPRK

Yonhap News Agency

US calls for coordinated international action on North Korean cyber threats after Binance hack

A State Department spokesperson told Yonhap that it is 'critical for governments to work together' to curb North Korean cyber revenue following the FBI's attribution of the Binance theft to DPRK actors. Seoul's Unification Ministry said Thursday it had not yet begun sanctions discussions because the full circumstances of the theft had not been established, while MOFA said it was 'reviewing' options, a split the Ministry described as a 'dilemma' between international cooperation and inter-Korean engagement.

US-KOREA

imaeil

South Korea's nuclear submarine program to formally launch in 2027 after feasibility study waived

Seoul waived the standard feasibility study requirement for the Korean-type nuclear submarine program, allowing the project to begin in 2027 on an accelerated schedule.

ROK ECONOMY

viva100

Democratic Party demands comprehensive property tax relief, Cheong Wa Dae holds firm on residency distinction

The ruling Democratic Party demanded the government apply the 1.4 billion won comprehensive real estate tax (jongbusae) basic deduction to all single-homeowners regardless of residency at a party-government consultation. The Presidential Office stated it would maintain the existing position distinguishing resident and non-resident homeowners, as set in the September tax reform bill.

15 | SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

Elevated or alert, 2 of 11 sites: Yongbyon Nuclear Complex; Sohae Satellite Launch Station.

No new reporting on any of the 11 monitored sites since the last issue.

That's today's brief. No. 228

Feedback and tips are welcome. Write to **alim@csis.org**.

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